Graphic Design

Interactive PDF and E-Publications

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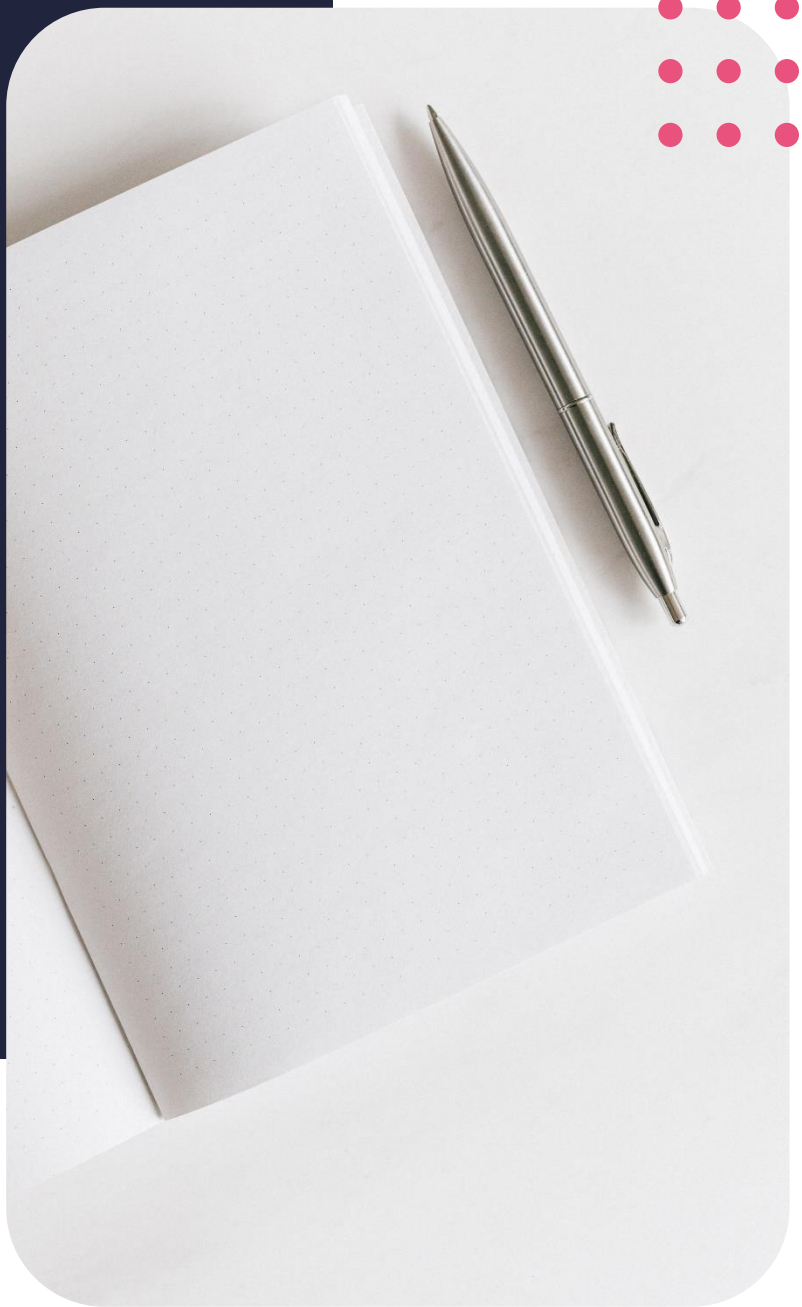


Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Lesson outcome 1: What is digital publications?
- Lesson outcome 2: The difference between interactive PDF & e-publications
- Lesson outcome 3: PDF documents advantages and disadvantages
- Lesson outcome 4: E-pub advantages and disadvantages
- Lesson outcome 5: Which format is bet to use?
- Lesson outcome 6: Demo: Digital publications

Introduction

Digital publication has been available for a lot longer than anticipated by most, but it has become a norm nowadays. This is also the reason why we will investigate digital publication and specifically the most popular and effective versions at the current time.

Did you know the first version of Adobe Acrobat, the software capable of reading PDF files were launched in the early 1993? There were two reasons why Adobe worked on this project. Firstly, A PDF document's aim was to allow its users to view the file precisely – and this is exactly what a pdf document did and secondly, it was viewable on multiple platforms and operating systems whether you viewed the document on Windows, Mac, or Linux.

The problem back then was that since Acrobat Reader was not free, it took quite some time for the file format to become popular.

Nowadays, pdf files are probably the most popular digital publication format and most used by everyone.

Pioneer digital designer and art director Muriel Cooper was known for embracing electronic communication and applied a Bauhaus perspective to her design outlook. This quote epitomises Muriel and digital design. "Information is only useful when it can be understood". She was known for breaking complex digital data into visually interesting but digestible chunks.

Design should be functional and should be done in such a way that it makes the user's experience interesting and valuable.

What is digital publications?

Digital publications can also be referred to as electronic publications or online publications. In short, we can say that it is the modern version of the printed book, magazine, brochure or newspaper.

Digital publication is simply the term used to define an electronic document, irrespective of the format it is saved in. We get digital publications in a variety of formats including Microsoft word documents, pdf documents and epubs. These are also some of the more popular formats.

By now, your knowledge is advanced enough to create a pdf document, but we will specifically look at creating interactive pdfs as well as e-publications today. The application we will be making use of is InDesign, although Illustrator can also work. InDesign is however better equipped to create these types of documents and offer more interactivity which Illustrator does not. So, I would suggest you rather stick to InDesign if there are any interactivity like hyperlinks, videos and audio in your digital publication.

Most, if not all, are familiar with a pdf document. PDF stands for portable document format and these documents are the world's standard format for digital documents. It is basically the good old paper documents, but in digital format, however you can make the document interactive by adding hyperlinks, videos and forms to fill in.

E publishing is a flexible and interactive digital document that was designed with all digital devices in mind. In other words, regardless of your device screens size or ratio, an ePub will adapt to make the reading experience easier. Epubs are mostly used for novels and books but can be used for other digital documents like manuals and programmes as well. Epub also offer a great interactive experience.

The difference between interactive PDF and e-publications

A pdf is a digital "piece of paper" and the size is dependent on the device you are using. Thus, the smaller the device screen, the more difficult it will be to read what is on this document.

An ePub's layout is responsive. Meaning that the layout of your document adapts to your screen size without jeopardising the readability of the content.

Both have this in common though: you need a special application to view these documents. In the case of a pdf document, Acrobat reader is probably the most popular but there are other free pdf readers as well.

In the case of an ePub, you get dedicated devices that are made to view these documents known as e-book readers or a Kindle . These devices can however also view pdf documents. If you don't own an e-book reader, you can simply install a reader application on your computer or smartphone. Most of these are free. When I work on a Windows computer, I make use of Adobe Digital Edition and when I work on a Mac, I make use of the already installed Apple Books.

PDF Documents advantages and disadvantages

So, when deciding which format to use, you need to understand their advantages and disadvantages first. We will firstly look at what a pdf document has to offer.

Advantages:

It is the most widely used digital publication format

The layout is uniform irrespective of the digital device you are viewing it on.

PDF's look the same printed as in digital format.

PDF's can be viewed, created or saved on almost any platform or device without installing additional software or applications, meaning it is an open standard.

PDF's can consist of only one page or 1000's of pages.

Disadvantages:

Due to its consistent and uniformed layout, it becomes difficult to view or read on smaller devices

Since the layout is not reflowable, it does not adapt to your device's screen size or ratio.

Since interactive pdf documents rely heavily on flash for its interactivity and media, it might or might not work, depending on the software you are viewing the document on. Acrobat reader is usually your best bet when it comes to experiencing the interactivity and media on your device, but Flash Player needs to be installed separately and as of 2020, Flash is no longer be available.

E-pub advantages and disadvantages

Let's have a look at the advantages and disadvantages of an epub document.

Advantages:

The first advantage of an epub is that the layout is reflowable. This means that the layout of type and images will adapt depending on the device you are viewing the ePub on.

You can actually also save an ePub file in a fixed layout format as well. This comes in very handy when you want specific images or animation aligned to specific paragraphs of type. We will look at how to save your ePub in just a minute.

The interactivity that includes hyperlinks, animation, media and sound on ePubs are very rich and allows you great control to make your document engaging.

The same as with a pdf is that an ePub can consist of only one page or 1000's of pages.

Disadvantages:

The disadvantages of an ePub are that you cannot simply save any document into an ePub format but need special applications or software. InDesign is one of these programs however.

Even though ePub has so much more to offer, especially on the interactivity side of digital publications, it is not as popular as pdf documents.

In order to view or edit ePub documents, you will most probably need to install additional software. However, there are numerous applications free of charge that allows you to access ePub files. It is only because pdf documents are so popular that all new devices come with a pdf reader.

Which format is best to use?

At the end of the day, it all depends on your outcome. Even though ePub documents offer a rich interactive experience, pdf documents are still preferred by most people. My personal opinion; save a document as a pdf when you are considering to have it in digital as well as print format. This can also be viewed and accessed by most people. This is for non-interactive pdf documents. If you have interactivity in your document, make sure that it won't jeopardise the quality and output of your pdf. In other words, your document will still look amazing without all the interactive features.

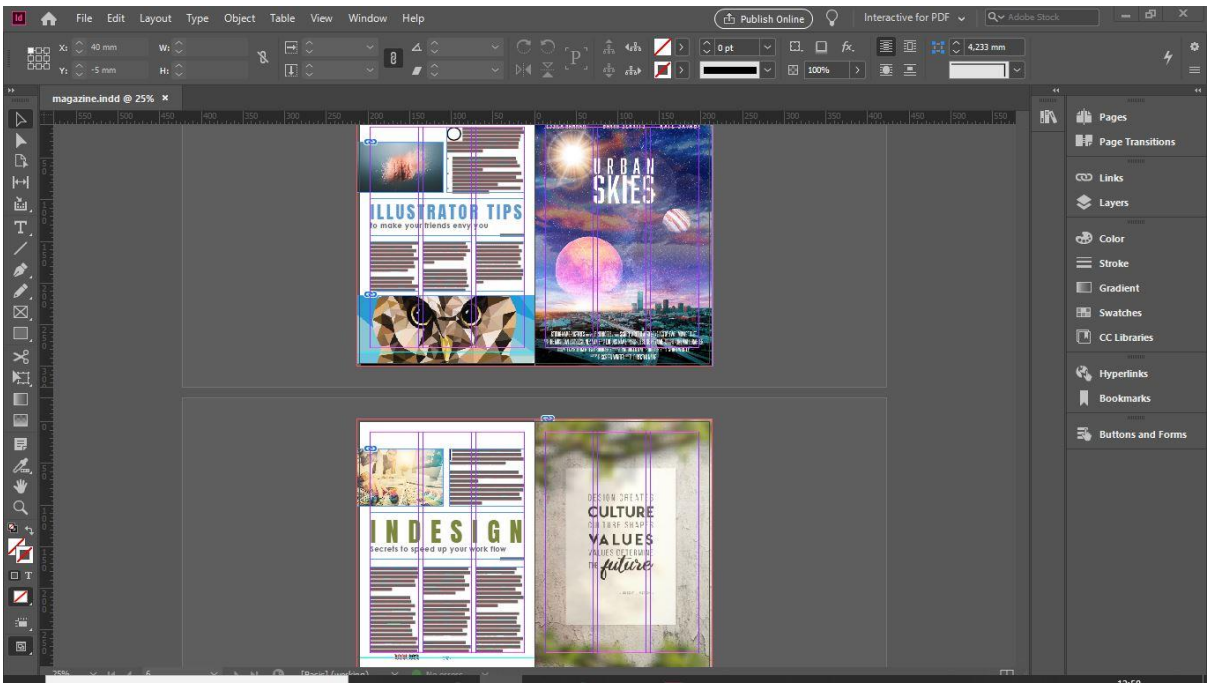
If you would like to have the document in digital format with interactive features like animations, videos and audio, you can save it as an ePub. You can upload your ePub using the Publish online feature in InDesign. Alternatively, simply install an ePub reader that you can download for free.

Learn to work with the interactive for pdf and digital publishing workspaces in InDesign. It really makes the process of creating digital publications fun and easier than learning XHTML and CSS coding. ePub documents contain XHTML and

CSS, so InDesign is an amazing wysiwyg (what you see is what you get) editor – make use of its abilities. If you don't understand what I just said, simply enjoy the ability to design digital publications.

Demo: Digital publication

I would like to create both an interactive pdf document as well as an ePub in InDesign for our demo. I will be making use of most of the content from our Design Unite pdf created in previous lessons.



Please refer to the video lesson for the demo

Conclusion

We looked at what digital publication is. We then examined the difference between interactive pdf documents as well as ePublications. Then, we looked at their advantages and disadvantages.

We ended off with an InDesign demo on creating an interactive pdf as well as an ePub.

I hope that you have learnt a lot in today's lesson. Go and impress your friends and create your very first digital publication.

References

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- Koenig Solutions, 2012, *How to Create EPub in InDesign?* YouTube. Available at: https://www.youtube.com/watch?time_continue=35&v=ACgdMQE0HZY&feature=emb_logo
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